GLASSHOUSE

SEATING PERKS

The new Congress MP from Wayanad, **Priyanka Gandhi Vadra**, has been assigned seat No. 517 in the fourth row in the Lok Sabha, where she will be flanked by the party's **Adoor Prakash** (Attingal, Kerala) and **Pradyut Bordoloi** (Nowgong, Assam), both in their second terms. This has sparked speculation within the Congress on whether the seat alignment would also alter the star alignments of both MPs. It has happened before. From 2014 to 2019, Kerala MP K.C. Venugopal was seated next to Rahul Gandhi in the 16th Lok Sabha; he is now among the top five decision-makers in the party. Similar is the case of Assam's Gaurav Gogoi, now the party's deputy leader in the Lok Sabha. Rahul even sent a letter to the LS speaker ahead of the winter session, requesting a front row seat for Gogoi. Will the trend now favour two others from Kerala and Assam?



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE



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PASS THE POPCORN

December 2 turned into a cinematic double feature for our lawmakers. Prime Minister **Narendra Modi** and an entourage of senior BJP leaders were at the Balayogi Auditorium in the Parliament library for a screening of *The Sabarmati Report*. The film, a 'true story' of the 2002 Godhra train arson incident that claimed 59 lives and led to the Gujarat riots that claimed some 2,000 more, received glowing reviews. Meanwhile, across town the same day, Samajwadi Party MP Jaya Bachchan hosted a screening of son Abhishek Bachchan's *I Want to Talk* for fellow MPs. This one, too, was a true story, based on a cancer survivor's resilience.

Soren vs Sarma





Fresh off his swearing-in, Jharkhand CM **Hemant Soren** says he is sending a team to Assam to study the "struggles" of tribal tea garden workers there. This is seen as a jab at the state's CM **Himanta Biswa Sarma**, who had led the BJP charge in the Jharkhand polls and accused Soren of aiding Bangladeshi infiltrators in the tribal lands. Not one to back down, Sarma has vowed to send teams of his own to track any wrongs in Jharkhand.

Planting a Victory





Maharashtra's first-time MLAs, **Babasaheb Deshmukh** of the Peasants and Workers Party of India, who won from Sangola in Solapur, and the BJP's **Rahul Awade,** who won from Ichalkaranji, have decided to celebrate their wins by planting trees matching the number of votes in their winning margins in the election. May their tribe increase.

SECOND STOPS

The second innings of retired Railway Board members is drawing a lot of unwanted attention. Ravinder Goyal, who retired as member, operations and business development, last week, has been shortlisted as a member in the Railway Claims Tribunal (RCT). Roopa Srinivasan, member, finance, too, is in the RCT list, even though her retirement is almost a year away.

The biggest twist involves **Jaya Verma Sinha,** the celebrated ex-chairperson of the Railway Board, who was denied in the same RCT selection round. But wasn't she 'banned' for refusing a post-retirement role at the Central Administrative Tribunal (CAT) in Kerala? She has, of course, contested the 'ban'.



RAJWANT RAWAT

Kaushik Deka with Amitabh Srivastava, Avishek G. Dastidar and Dhaval S. Kulkarni